

purchases they make.

19 Crimes, a wine label established by Treasury Wine Estates, launched AR app Living Wine Labels. On hovering a smartphone camera in front of the wine bottle, mug shots of notorious 18th century British criminals (convicts who committed one of the nineteen crimes punishable by exile to Australia) come alive as 3D characters who narrate their story to amuse wine drinkers.

The marketing strategy was simple, creative, entertaining and enhanced consumers' experience. As the experience was surprising and unexpected, consumers were eager to share it with family, friends and social networks. Sales of 19 Crimes increased, helping them become one of the fastest-growing brands.

Making AR marketing a success

The following aspects can guide one towards using AR effectively for marketing purposes:

Consider holistic customer experience. Do not pick AR technology just because it is the latest and fashionable. Before investing think about the holistic customer experience and the purpose AR would actually serve to enhance it. AR should be used when it is essential to showcase content as part of the environment.

Focus on simple, straightforward concept. The campaign should not be overcomplicated; rather it should be simple and straightforward, providing a simple and interesting way to bring the desired experience to shoppers. The campaign should be memorable,



AR mirror developed by Italian beauty retailer Sephora (Credit: YouTube)

making shoppers wanting to share it with others and help on taking a purchase decision.

Make AR experiences Aha! moments. Shoppers should be provided necessary instructions and technical help to guide them. Those who are less tech-savvy will need extra technical help. The AR experience should trigger an Aha! moment and light up their faces.

AR experience should be useful, not just fun. The AR marketing campaign should be useful, educating and convenient. Fun and usefulness should be combined. For example, Ben & Jerry's AR ice-cream lids, while making the brand image playful, educated shoppers about usefulness of the ingredients used.

Design the AR experience considering the environment. Take advantage of the physical environment, be aware of where and how users will be interacting with the content—out on the streets, at home or inside a shopping mall; in a rush or at leisure—how far will they be from the products they scan, will they be using their own mobile data or like to connect to a hotspot, and what would be the best moment to make them try the experience.

Test effectiveness of the experience. It is important to test the AR experience before launching, to check its usability, whether it resonates with shoppers and whether they will understand the concept as intended. Consider providing free trials and demo

apps to try out the concept.

Measure profitability. At the end of the day, it is profitability that wins the race. ROI counts the most. Some of the ways that can be used to measure the success and ROI are media coverage, increased brand value, engagement time spent and number of interactions, and clicks needed to make a purchase.

The future

AR and VR technologies are making the in-store experience truly fun and innovative. They improve interactivity, level of engagement and offer great excitement. The experience cannot be equalled by online shopping and will be of great assistance to the brick-and-mortar retail stores to considerably increase the numbers of shoppers. This is more applicable to India, where physical stores are struggling against huge discounts being offered by online shopping sites.

The technologies can be explored in several ways by retailers to improve their customer base and enhance customer satisfaction. These technologies are adaptable for many uses as they integrate physical and digital worlds. Enormous opportunity is available to combine online and offline experiences into an omni-channel marketing strategy to improve sales.

While AR and VR technologies have been around for quite some time, businesses are only just learning and experiencing their true potential. There is plenty still to be explored to make AR and VR technologies work to promote businesses and brands. The technologies provide great opportunities to explore and experiment with out-of-the-box brand engagement to increase sales and help strengthen the bond with customers.

Adoption of these technologies may have been slow, but undoubtedly the technologies are set to become highly popular and useful. Mixed reality (MR), also known as hybrid reality or extended reality (XR), is an intersection between VR and AR, and joins the finest aspects of both technologies. **EFY**



Hybrid reality is the way for the future (Credit: <https://whooptous.com>)